One sunny morning in April 1978, Prime Minister Morarji Desai woke up to a report on the American broadcasting channel NBC that made a startling disclosure about a CIA operation in the Indian Himalayas to carry out espionage activities on China codenamed Operation HAT. The text of the news report was sent to the Prime Minister's Office (PMO). The report said: 'Somewhere high in the Himalayan mountain range that separates India and China, a nuclear power pack filled with plutonium 238 is buried in the snow and rocks. The story on the American television channel raised the question—how did the nuclear device get there in the first place?'

In a telegram to the prime minister, the Indian embassy in Washington claimed that the US media had picked up the story and it was bound to create a storm back home. It did. Joint Secretary A.G. Asrani, who looked after America and Canada in the MEA, wrote to the

R&AW and IB chiefs on 14 April that the issue had triggered a political storm in Parliament. Asrani's note said:

Reports have appeared in the Press regarding the planting of a nuclear monitoring device in the Himalayas by an American mountaineering team in 1965. As would have been seen in this morning's newspapers, our grave concern has been conveyed by the foreign secretary to the Ambassador of USA. The latter has told us that the US government is looking into the matter and that he would let us know as soon as he gets some information from Washington.

Later, Outside magazine released a comprehensive story stating that the spy station was set up in coordination with Indian spy agencies, though they wrongly named the CBI (Central Bureau of Investigation) instead of the Intelligence Bureau. The article